

international success.

"Unfortunately, both the government and private entities have still not fully understood the potential of winter sports," Farhat told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of KIWG 2025.

Only two Indian snowboarders, Zubair Ahmad Lone and Mehraj Ud Din Khan, competed in the FIS Freestyle Ski and Snowboard World Championships in St. Moritz, Switzerland this year (which started on March 18).

"Every snow sport, including snowboarding, is costly. Athletes need equipment, top training facilities, and exposure to international events, for which they need solid backing. Only Zubair and Mehraj secured sponsorship. You cannot produce elite athletes without investment," he added.

From 700 athletes in 2023 to over 900 in the latest KIWG, the event has expanded. This expansion aligns with increased international involvement, evidenced by FIS-supported European development camps and a record 59-athlete delegation at the 2025 Asian Winter Games in China. These developments contribute to India's ongoing preparations for the 2026 Winter Olympics in Milan.

In the past, snow sports were exclusively operated by the Indian Army and were confined to the northern states. However, things are changing, according to Vineet Kumar, Deputy Director General, Sports Authority of India, Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports, Patiala.

"The growing popularity of winter sports, evidenced by participants from southern, central, eastern, and western states, not just the traditional northern regions, is a

very encouraging sign for India. To capitalise on this momentum, we need to create artificial facilities for year-round athlete practice, which will further increase civilian participation and reduce the current reliance on the armed forces," he explained.

Navigating through challenges

One of the major stumbling blocks for winter sports in India is the lack of facilities. There are still only three key resorts: Manali in Himachal Pradesh; Gulmarg in Kashmir; and Auli in Uttarakhand, where the country's only International Ski and Snowboard Federation (FIS) approved ski slope is located.

There has also been a lack of National Sports Federation (NSF) accreditation for winter sports federations, which hinders the broader development of the sports.

Priti Thakur, who won gold in women's snowboarding slalom, highlighted the hardship faced by athletes while progressing from the national stage to the international level.

"To compete at the international level, I require financial support. Coming from a humble background, I lack access to the necessary equipment. Specifically, I need a hardboard for FIS races, which costs approximately ₹2.5 lakhs, as my current softboard is unsuitable," she said.

The changing weather patterns and the rising global temperature are making things even more complicated. The KIWG 2025 was scheduled for mid-February but had to be postponed due to a lack of snowfall at 2,700 metres above sea level in winter.

"Winter sports are inevitably dependent on weather. Yes, we need more facilities to grow winter sports in the country, especially amid the changing weather patterns. Maintaining natural slopes is also a difficult task," said Dr. Nadeem Ahmad Dar, one of the directors of SAI.

A new horizon

Amid the shortfalls, SkiMo — a recent addition to the Winter Olympics set to debut in Milan 2026 — is rapidly gaining popularity in India, largely due to its low infrastructure requirements.

"This is an ideal sport for India's Himalayan regions, offering vast potential for both athletic development and adventure tourism," opined Praveen Sood, the president of the National Ski Mountaineering Association of India.

Sood, a seasoned skier, also highlighted the broader vision for the sport. "SkiMo is an endurance sport and gives us (Indians) an opportunity to make it to the top.

